University of Sheffield

Research Ethics for COM PGT dissertations

School of Computer Science

Mark Hepple
Principal Ethics Lead

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Research ethics policy

Why does the University have an Research Ethics Policy?

- About protecting dignity, rights, safety and well-being of participants and data subjects
- Applies to all staff & students doing research with people or their data (or their tissues)
- Ethics approval is required **BEFORE** the relevant activity commences, or this prior activity constitutes an ***ethics breach***

Ethics Approval for PGT Dissertation Projects

- If your project involves testing with, or data collection from human participants, the collection of personal data, or use of data that might contain personal information, then ethics approval is required
- Where to start?
  - PGT Dissertation Project page in PGT student handbook has a link to a page about about the Ethics Review Procedure - read this
  - See also: `https://students.sheffield.ac.uk/research-ethics/ethics/brief-guide`
  - Discuss with your supervisor
    - Whether an application is needed for your project
    - What information to provide for an application to go through

Timeliness - Be aware

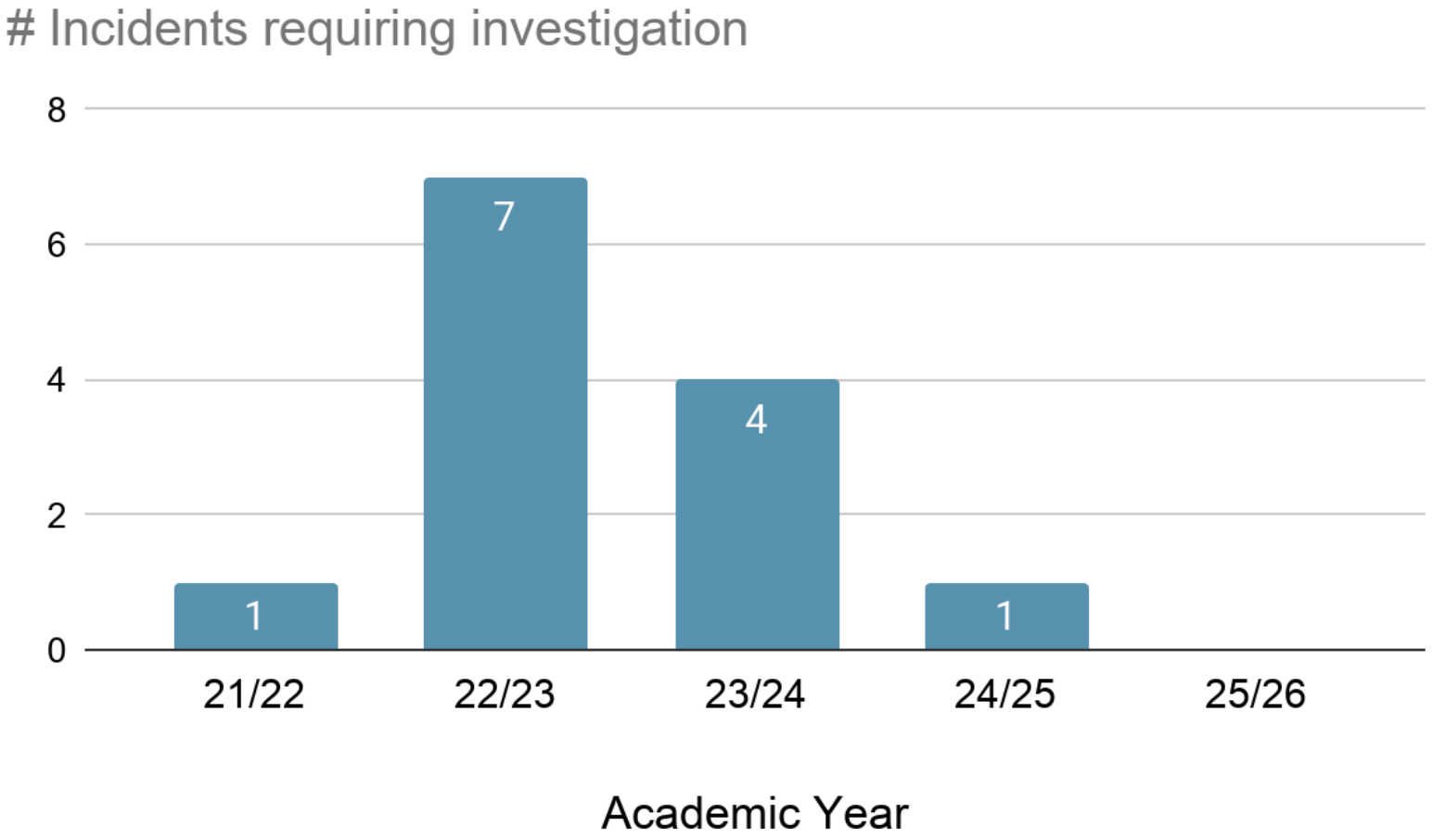
- Prepare your ethics application in good time
- Applications can take two weeks to get approval
  - May take longer if considered “high risk”
  - Can take longer if application needs amending and re-submitting
- Work that requires approval cannot begin until approval is granted
- But … don’t apply *too early*
  - You need to be able to provide a detailed and correct description of the methodology

Applying for Ethics Approval - preparation

- There are three online courses on *information security* that you must complete
- Must complete them BEFORE you can submit an application
- The three courses are:
  - Information Management (approx. 20 minutes)
  - Data Protection (approx. 10 minutes)
  - Protecting Research Data (approx. 10 minutes)

Ethics Breaches

An *ethics breach* occurs if work is done that requires ethics approval that is not in place. Ethics approval must be given *before* work begins.



Figures for this year available only after all dissertations have been marked !!

Incidents requiring investigation

- All these incidents were related to student projects.
- Nearly all were cases where ethics approval was required but hadn’t been applied for
  - (except one where approval was granted but not correctly followed)
- Some were due to misunderstanding by staff.
- Others due to students submitting evaluations that their supervisors had not been aware of.

Consequences of an ‘Ethics breach’

- Head of Department has to be notified.
- UREC have to be contacted.
- A detailed investigation has to take place.
  - Interviews with the supervisor
  - Interviews with the student
  - Evidence from email trails etc
  - Final decisions made by UREC
- Potential consequences for student
  - Loss of marks
  - Could lead to failure of dissertation
  - Disciplinary action
  - Delay in obtaining degree

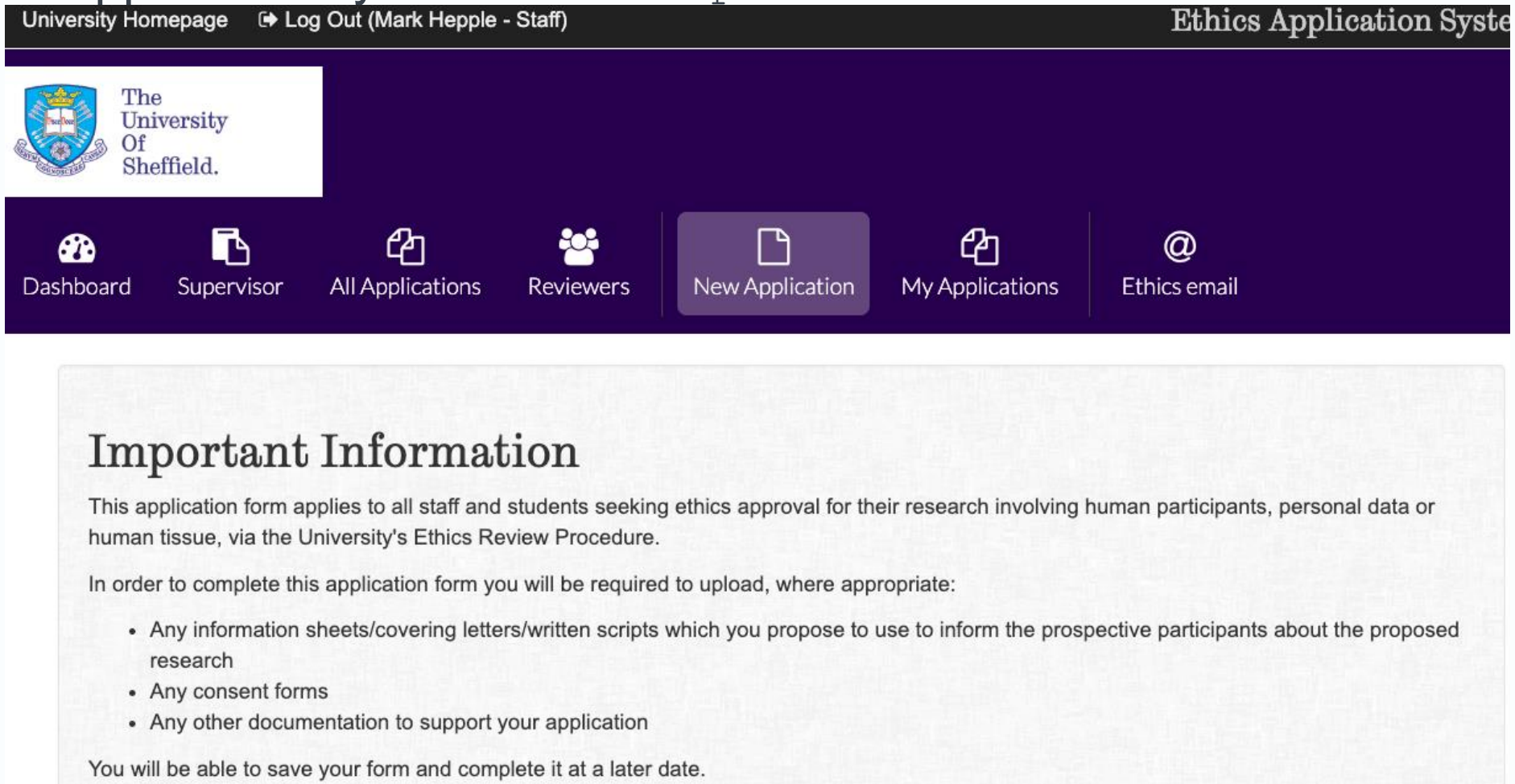
I’m uncertain if my project needs approval …

What if I’m uncertain if my project needs ethics approval?

- First, discuss the question with your supervisor
- If you are still uncertain, send a query to the com-ethics@ email
    - State your question clearly, and include enough information
    - cc your supervisor to keep them in the loop (required!)
- If the ethics admin staff are unable to answer your question, they will forward it to the COM School Ethics Lead

Applying for Ethics Approval

- Ethics application system: `https://ethics.ris.shef.ac.uk/`



UG/PGT Process - supervisor involvement

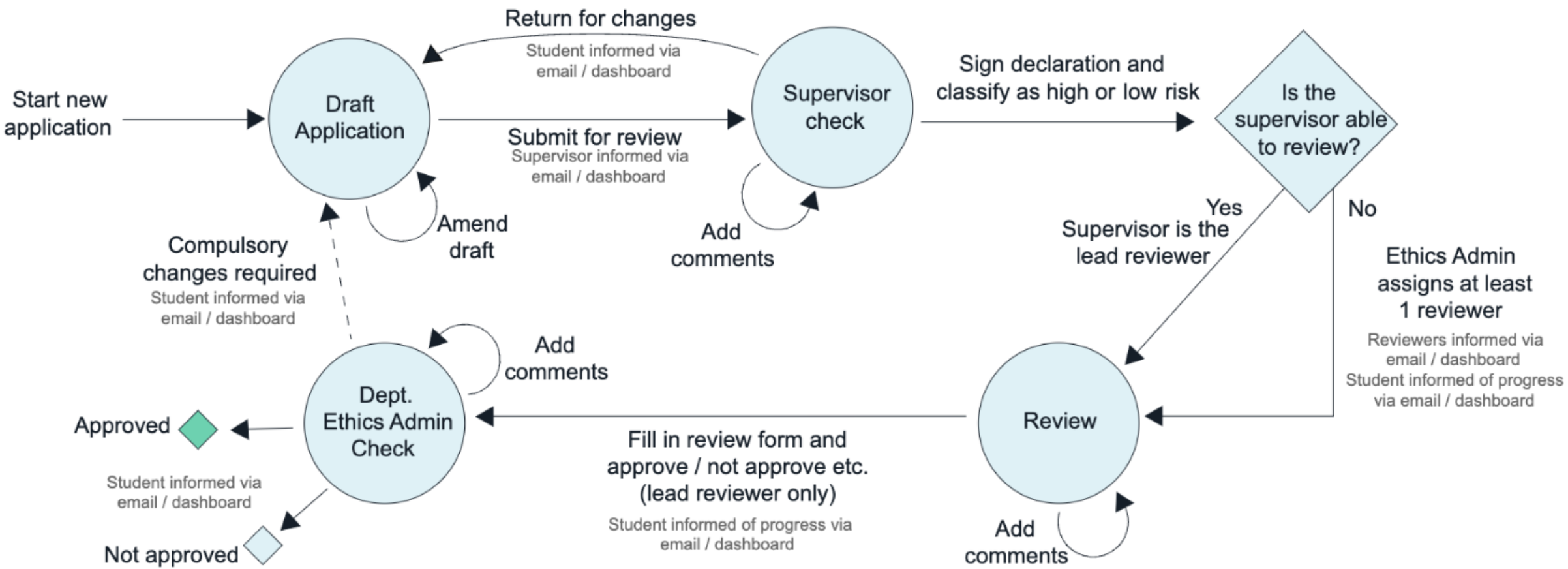
1. Student drafts application on system

2. Supervisor check
   - returns to student if changes needed
   - student resubmits

3. Risk assessment
   - Supervisor assesses if proposed work is low or high risk

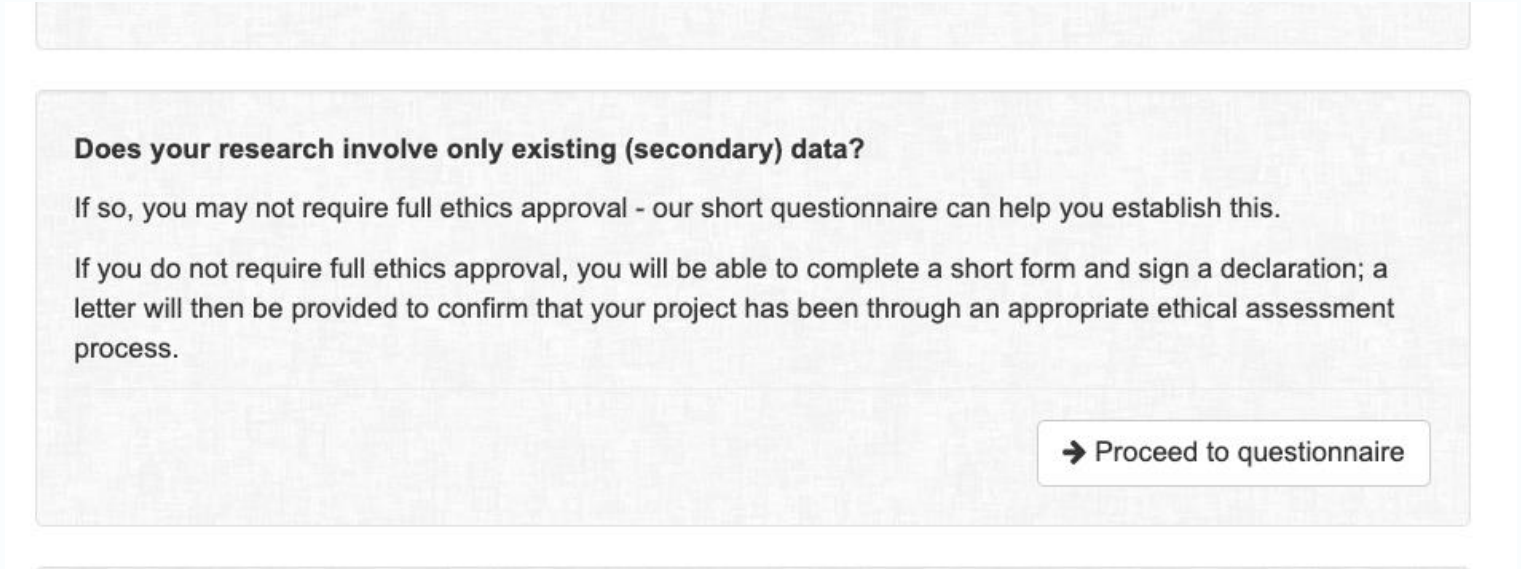
3. Ethical review
   - If **low** risk – supervisor makes ethical review decision in system
   - If **high** risk – Ethics Admin will assign 2 additional reviewers

Ethics Application Process for Student Projects



Ethics Application with Self-declaration

- Some projects may NOT require *full* ethics approval
  - Instead, a simpler form of application may be allowed
  - Known as *self-declaration*
- When is self-declaration possible?
  - If the project involves ONLY pre-existing (secondary) data about people/subjects
  - AND certain other criteria are satisfied
  - The ethics “New Application” page has a questionnaire to help you determine whether self-declaration is sufficient



Self Declaration

- Presents a series of Yes/No questions (each with explanatory text)
- Only some choice-paths leads to "*Continue to self-declaration form*" outcome
- Otherwise, need to submit a full application

Will you be undertaking any primary data collection involving human participants or personal data as part of your project?
No

Will the dataset that you plan to use for this project have been fully anonymised before you, or any other member of the research team (including any supervisors), are given access to it?
Yes

Could your analysis and subsequent reporting of findings lead to the re-identification of data subject(s), by yourselves or any third party (e.g. the data provider)?
No

Has consent been obtained from the original data subjects for the secondary use of their data for research purposes?
Yes

Can you be reasonably sure that the research you will be undertaking is unlikely to cause offence to the original data subjects, should they become aware of it?
Yes

Informed consent

For any work involving human subjects (testing, data collection, etc):

- Must provide a ***Participant Information Sheet***
  - Provide sufficient information to enable decision to take part or not
  - Use language & approach appropriate to participants
  - No coercion
  - Clear info re: options for withdrawal from participation
- Must provide a ***Consent Form***
  - Require written consent for in-person participation
  - Electronic consent for online participation

Ethics Application Quiz

“I don’t need to apply for ethical approval because…

“I don’t need to apply for ethical approval because…

… I am surveying people online using a Google Form which provides anonymous responses”



“I don’t need to apply for ethical approval because…

… I am surveying people online using a Google Form which provides anonymous responses”



We are still carrying out research with human participants, therefore we need to:

- Apply for ethics approval
- Attach a *Consent form* and a *Participant Information Sheet* (PIS)
    - If desired, the PIS can be linked from the Google Form and the Consent form can be integrated in the survey but MUST be submitted for ethics approval
- Collect participants’ consent

“I don’t need to apply for ethical approval because…

… I am just testing the system on myself and I’m happy to give myself consent.”



“I don’t need to apply for ethical approval because…

… I am just testing the system on myself and I’m happy to give myself consent.”



- Of course, a developer (researcher/student) will constantly test a system while developing it.
- **BUT** if they cast themself in role of *subject, from whom data is collected, for inclusion in a paper (or dissertation),* then approval is required. Need to:
  - Apply for ethics approval
  - Attach a *Consent form* and a *Participant Information Sheet*
  - Collect (record) participant(s)’ consent

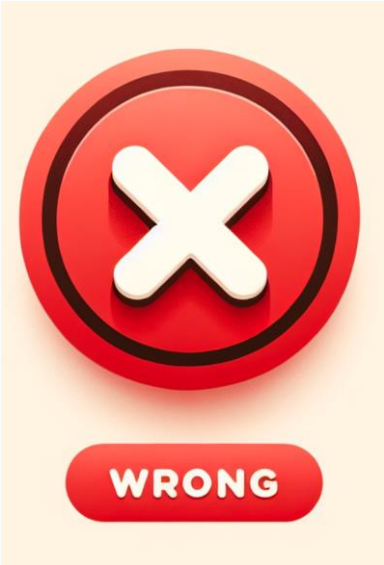
“I don’t need to apply for ethical approval because…

… I am only collecting feedback on my software and the feedback is non-identifiable.”



“I don’t need to apply for ethical approval because…

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Even if no personal data is collected, we are still carrying out research with human participants, therefore we need to:

- Apply for ethics approval
- Attach a consent form and a *Participant Information Sheet*
- Collect participants’ consent

“I don’t need to apply for ethical approval because…

…I am annotating a dataset but using Amazon Turk and so I won’t know who the annotators are.”



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…I am analysing social media data that I’ve scraped off the web and it is impossible to ask for individual consent”



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…I am analysing social media data that I’ve scraped off the web and it is impossible to ask for individual consent”



We are still collecting data from human participants to carry out research, therefore we need to:

- Apply for ethics approval
- Refer to the social media research specialist guidelines (at link below)

https://students.sheffield.ac.uk/research-services/ethics-integrity/research-ethics/policy-note-14

“I don’t need to apply for ethical approval because…

…I am using a social media dataset that’s downloadable and was collected by others.”



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Data may include posts, or other information, that allows the social media users to be (re-)identified, therefore we need to:

- Apply for ethics approval
- Refer to the social media research specialist guidelines (at link below)
- If using anonymous datasets, that include no individual posts, from which social media user cannot be identified, may be able to submit a *Self-declaration*

https://students.sheffield.ac.uk/research-services/ethics-integrity/research-ethics/policy-note-14

Examples of studies requiring ethics approval…

- Interviews
- Surveys
- Focus groups
- Experiments on people (including researcher themselves!)
- Social media data
- Existing/online datasets containing personal data (i.e. data from which individuals could be identified)

Examples of studies which don't require ethics approval

- Published digital or print media (news/magazine articles) or public broadcasts, for public consumption
- Survey of staff/students to obtain feedback on a departmental process/service which will only be used internally (not research)
- In certain case, use of an anonymised secondary dataset does not require a *full* ethics application
  - Can instead use self-declaration form on ethics system

Potentially sensitive topics

- ‘race’ or ethnicity
- trade union membership
- religious, spiritual or other beliefs
- physical or mental health conditions
- sex life, sexuality and/or gender identity
- identity of an individual resulting from processing of genetic or biometric data
- abuse (child, adult)
- nudity and the body
- criminal or illegal activities
- political asylum
- conflict situations
- personal violence
- terrorism or violent extremism
- personal finances
- political opinion

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Fundamental ethical principles

Participant rights:

- informed consent
- safety/wellbeing
- confidentiality
- security (data/samples)

Researcher obligations:

- honesty
- integrity
- minimising risks
- respect for others

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Informed consent

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Safety and well-being

- Potential for harm, distress or inconvenience?
- Manage and minimise risks
- Inform participants of potential risks
- Contacts for reporting concerns
- Risks to researchers/others?

See Research Ethics Policy Note no.3: https://students.sheffield.ac.uk/media/825/download

Safeguarding

- Consider risk of exploitation, abuse and harm to:
  - Participants
  - Researchers
  - Others who may be present during research
- Take steps to mitigate/manage risks
- Ensure more than one, accessible route for reporting concerns:
  - Designated safeguarding contact in research team
  - Contact outside of research team (e.g. HoD)

https://www.sheffield.ac.uk/research-services/ethics-integrity/safeguarding

Anonymity, confidentiality and data protection

- Use of ‘identifiable personal data’ must comply with relevant legislation (UK GDPR + DPA 2018)
- Define the ‘Data Controller’ & the legal basis for processing & how to raise concerns
- Only collect data required for the research
- Anonymise or pseudonymise data where possible
- Do not disclose participant identities without consent
- Data security measures –
  - e.g. use University-provided apps/services, encrypt mobile devices

See Policy Note no.4: https://students.sheffield.ac.uk/media/826/download

Tips for preparing ethics applications — #1

Keep updated:

- Ethics policy, and the recommendations for the structure/content of a *Consent form* and a *Participant Information Sheet* change over time
- Always check that you are using the latest example of Consent Form and PIS, do not just reuse one that you used in a past ethics application

Tips for preparing ethics applications — #2

Use clear language:

- Explain your research and WHAT you are asking ethics for in a clear and concise manner.
- The purpose of the ethics application is to show that all potential ethics issues have been considered and mitigated (not that your research is excellent)
- Provide enough information for reviewers to make decision

Tips for preparing ethics applications — #3

Details matter:

- Provide details about the methodology for
  - Recruiting participants
    - How many participants?
    - How will you recruit them?
- Conducting your study
  - How long will it last?
    - Where will you carry it out?
    - How?

Tips for preparing ethics applications — #5

Provide as much information as possible:

- When you plan a questionnaire or an interview, you should provide
  - A draft of the questions
- Sometimes the study is appropriate and ethically sound however the way questions are formulated is not

Tips for preparing ethics applications — #6

Put yourself in the participants shoes….



Key resources

- Ethics approval process: https://students.sheffield.ac.uk/research-services/ethics-integrity/atoz/approval-procedure
- Application guidance: https://students.sheffield.ac.uk/research-services/ethics-integrity/atoz/apply
- Guidance on documents to support an ethics application (information sheet, consent form, data collection tool, DMP etc.): https://students.sheffield.ac.uk/research-services/ethics-integrity/atoz/documents